WEST BENGAL

A POTATO BLIGHT IN BENGAL

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar



PROBLEM OF PLENTY
Potatoes being harvested in Paschim Medinipur district in West Bengal

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

Ashish Ghosh, a 48-year-old farmer from Paschim Medinipur district, had spent Rs 50,000 on his 2.5 bighas to cultivate potatoes. That small plot, about 1.55 acres, was a rented one. The money too was borrowed, almost all of a Rs 60,000 loan. A bountiful harvest would defray the damages and fetch returns. Or so he thought. But on-and-off restrictions on the sale of the crop to neighbouring states like Odisha and Bihar upset all his plans. West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee had imposed the ban twice—from July 2024 to mid-August and again from mid-October to January 24—to calm soaring potato prices in Kolkata. By the time the last ban was lifted, the decision had immiserated many thousands of farmers like Ghosh. That too, ironically, while cold storage units in Bengal are crammed full with last year's unsold potatoes, causing prices of millions of sacks of fresh produce to plummet.

The ban came at times when potato prices in Kolkata had rocketed up to Rs 40-45 a kg. The surge was due to the anticipation of a poor crop amidst uneven rainfall, compounded by supply chain issues. But the solution dealt a bitter blow to potato farmers and traders in the western districts of Paschim Medinipur, Purulia and Bankura, who grow 'inferior' varieties not sold in Kolkata. A ban meant their harvests, bound for neighbouring states, lay unsold in cold storages, leading to huge losses.

State agriculture minister Becharam Manna insists the situation was not mishandled. "Potatoes from Paschim Medinipur and Bankura did reach urban markets via traders in Hooghly between December and January," he says. On the ground, though, that ad-hoc relief was too little. Kamal Dey, head of the state's price monitoring task force, blames traders. "We requested them to sell at Rs 26 a kg. The CM revoked the first ban in mid-August. But they started selling at Rs 28 which, when it reached Kolkata, became Rs 35," Dey says. He asserts that this forced the government to seal borders again.

Potato cultivation costs between Rs 25,000-30,000 a bigha, and farmers usually earn between Rs 40,000 and Rs 60,000. This year, they can only make Rs 6,000 to Rs 8,000 a bigha. Potato is sown around October-November and is harvested from January to early March. Traders buy potatoes between January and March, storing them for nine-ten months. But with the borders shut, cold storages remain full with old stock. "From January 24, borders have been reopened. But Odisha has met its needs with imports from Uttar Pradesh and Punjab. Who will buy our potatoes?" asks Asit Pal, a member of a potato traders' lobbying group.

As traders struggle to dispose of last year's stocks, they are in no position to pay a good price for the new crop. Experts also predict that, if the weather is favourable this year, production could touch 15 million metric tonnes, potentially worsening the crisis. To avoid this, 30 per cent space in storages is being reserved to enable small farmers to store their crops. Production in the 2023-24 season was around 10 million MT.

Odisha, the biggest importer of Bengal potatoes, is also moving toward self-sufficiency through increased acreage. The 'export' ban, thus, might have done lasting damage to Bengal. In a cold storage INDIA TODAY visited in Sat Bankura in Paschim Medinipur, 15,000 to 20,000 sacks of old potatoes—cleared to make way for new ones—lie unclaimed outside. Some 600,000 such sacks remain unsold in that district alone—a symbol of the crushing burden of uncertainty and debt on Bengal's farmers. ■

TUBER TROUBLE

- **The state government banned sale of potatoes to neighbouring states**
- **This was to reduce high potato prices in Kolkata due to anticipation of a poor crop, supply issues**
- **The ban came in two phases: July-Aug. '24 and mid-Oct. '24 to Jan. 24, '25**
- **Replaced by new produce in cold storages, sacks of old potatoes lie rotting, ruining many farmers**